A MOM BOSS WELLNESS RESEARCH WHITE PAPER

The Sustainability Gap

Why High-Achieving Mothers are Breaking, Leaving, and Rebuilding

ORIGINAL INTERVIEW RESEARCH • 20+ INTERVIEWS • SUMMER 2026

AUTHOR'S NOTE

I leaned in. Motherhood asked for more

When the Lean In movement emerged early in my career, I leaned in: fully and without reservation. I climbed. I performed. I led. I made it to executive leadership, and my career was the centerpiece of my identity. It became who I was.

Then I had my first child.

What followed was something I was not prepared for: an identity crisis. The woman who had built everything around her career suddenly found herself trying to reconcile two versions of herself that the world had never told her could coexist. I had leaned in so hard that I had not left room for anything else. Motherhood demanded everything else.

As I continued to have children, the tension did not disappear; it deepened. I watched myself, and the women around me, trying to manage the same impossible equation. I tried to mitigate burnout before it hit. I tried to design a life that could hold both my career and my children without one consuming the other. Some seasons I got it right. Others, I did not.

What I kept noticing, though, was that I was not alone, and that no one was really talking about it honestly. Not in boardrooms. Not in Employee Resource Group (ERG) meetings. Not in the polished LinkedIn posts of high-achieving women who were quietly falling apart behind the scenes.

When the Women in the Workplace 2025 report was released, and with it the data behind what researchers began calling the "Great Exit," I knew it was time to stop observing and start documenting. I went directly to the source: I interviewed the high-achieving moms living this in real time, to understand where they were, what they had done about it, and what their journeys actually looked like from the inside.

This white paper is the result of those conversations.
It is honest. And it is long overdue.

WHY THIS RESEARCH, WHY NOW

The data sounded an alarm. The interviews explain it.

This research did not begin in a vacuum. It was catalyzed by a convergence of data points that painted an alarming picture of what is happening to high-achieving women, and particularly mothers, in the American workplace.

Two bodies of research sit at the foundation of this work: the McKinsey and LeanIn.Org Women in the Workplace 2025 report, the largest annual study of its kind, and the broader reporting on what has come to be called the "Great Exit," a wave of mothers leaving the workforce in 2025.

The Women in the Workplace 2025 report opened with a warning: only half of companies are now prioritizing women's career advancement, part of a multi-year decline in commitment to gender diversity, and for the first time, women are notably less interested in being promoted than men. The report describes this as a critical crossroads for corporate America.

Alongside this, the labor market told its own story. KPMG's 2025 report, The Great Exit, documented how return-to-office mandates and rising childcare costs combined to push working mothers out of the workforce at historic rates.

450,000+	42%	−3 pts
WOMEN EXITED THE U.S. WORKFORCE IN 2025	OF WOMEN WHO LEFT CITED CAREGIVING AS THE PRIMARY DRIVER	DROP IN LABOR FORCE PARTICIPATION, MOMS WITH KIDS UNDER 5

Sources: KPMG, The Great Exit (2025); Catalyst (2025); U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (2025). See Sources, page 10.

These are not just statistics. They are the women I interviewed. They are the women you work with. They are the women who were holding up entire organizations, quietly breaking under the weight, long before anyone outside their closest circle knew.

This research was designed to go beyond the data. To put faces, voices, and lived experience behind the numbers. To ask not just what is happening, but why, and what comes next.

THE OVERALL PICTURE

Five Key Takeaways from Women in the Workplace 2025

The report surfaces five findings that directly mirror what emerged in this research's interviews, and that framed the urgency behind this white paper.

1 **Senior women are burning out at record levels, and it is reshaping their ambition.** Six in ten senior-level women report frequent burnout, compared to about half of men at their level: the highest rate recorded in the study's history. Senior-level women are also far more likely than other employees to believe the leaders above them are burned out and unhappy. That perception is now a leading reason many women give for not wanting to advance further.

2 **The broken rung still exists, and representation erodes at every step up.** For the eleventh consecutive year, women remain underrepresented at every level of the corporate pipeline, holding just 29 percent of C-suite roles, unchanged from the year before. For every 100 men promoted to manager, only 93 women are promoted, and the gap widens further for women of color.

3 **Flexibility stigma is quietly punishing the women who need flexibility most.** Women who work remotely most of the time are far less likely to have a sponsor or to have been promoted in the last two years than women who work mostly on-site, while men's outcomes stay consistent regardless of where they work. This penalty hits hardest at the entry level, exactly where many new mothers are trying to hold on.

4 **Companies are quietly scaling back the very supports that help women most.** Only about half of companies now say women's career advancement is a high priority, a steep decline from years prior. At least one in six companies have cut staff or resources devoted to diversity, and many have scaled back career development, formal sponsorship, and flexible work options.

5 **When companies do invest, the payoff is measurable and real.** High-performing companies, those with greater representation of women across every level, have seen meaningfully faster progress since 2021 than companies that under-invest. Employees who experience their workplace as fair and inclusive are at least twice as likely to feel motivated, take risks, and speak up, and significantly less likely to burn out or consider leaving.

WHAT THE INTERVIEWS REVEALED

Seven patterns, one collective truth

Before the breaking point, high-achieving moms in leadership consistently put themselves last. They are operating in systems, corporate and otherwise, that were not designed with them in mind, yet they continue to push forward at full velocity. For nearly all of them, the shift only became undeniable when the body and mind demanded it. These conversations were honest and open; names and identifying details are not included. Seven patterns emerged, regardless of industry, seniority, or family structure.

01 Burnout is nearly universal

Among the moms interviewed, burnout has been a near-universal experience within the past two years. It stems from operating without boundaries, working around the clock, and managing a household without adequate support systems in place. Their responses fell into three distinct patterns:

- Stepping back temporarily to recharge.
- Remaining in a prolonged state of burnout with no clear path forward.
- Taking a complete break from their role entirely.

02 It is a health crisis, and the cost of constant access

The toll is not just professional; it is deeply physical and mental. Moms reported significant health issues, postpartum depression, and rising mental health challenges alongside sustained stress and the pressure to carry it all. For many, the body forces the conversation that the mind was not ready to have.

At the core of this health crisis is the cost of constant access. Many of these women are living in a chronic state of fight or flight, nervous systems perpetually activated, never given the space to reset. Because work is always accessible, the boundary between on and off has dissolved. Even the language of the modern workplace reinforces this dysregulation: corporate culture is filled with terms like fire drills, putting out fires, and dropping everything, phrases that signal urgency and crisis even when none truly exists.

> “Not everything is a fire. Words shape nervous systems.”

03 The mindset divide: lost vs. found

Mindset emerged as one of the most telling fault lines in this research. The moms who remained lost in their burnout often struggled to see a way forward, still carrying the full weight without the tools, community, or self-permission to put any of it down. The moms who broke through did so by crossing a threshold moment: a point of reckoning that forced a shift from victimhood to agency. This crossing rarely happened in isolation. It was catalyzed by community, by honest conversations with other women who had been through it.

04 A system not built for them

Corporate structures, career timelines, performance expectations, meeting cultures: all were built around a different kind of worker, in a different era. Many moms have internalized this mismatch as a personal failure. It is not. It is a structural one. The women who have found their way through are those who stopped trying to fit themselves into a broken mold and instead built, or found, something that actually fit their lives.

05 Presence becomes the North Star

Once the shift happens, presence becomes a guiding value. Moms begin to put down the phone, protect family time, and make deliberate choices about where their energy goes. Being present, for their children, their partners, and themselves, emerged as a consistent and deeply felt aspiration across every stage of the journey.

06 Building the village

A recurring theme is the intentional construction of a support system, what many describe as a paid village. This runs counter to the dominant cultural narrative in the U.S., which does not naturally encourage communal support structures. Yet the moms who have thrived have found ways to build and invest in that village anyway.

07 The pivot toward meaningful work

These moms are no longer willing to simply grind. They are asking deeper questions about what their work means and whether it is worth the cost. The deliberate pivot toward meaningful work was one of the most refreshing and recurring themes across every interview.

> “Many moms have internalized this mismatch as a personal failure. It is not. It is a structural one.”

THE FIVE FACES OF THIS MOVEMENT

Each one is real. Each one is someone you know.

STILL IN THE SYSTEM. RUNNING ON FUMES.

The Mom Running on Empty

She is in a corporate leadership role, performing at a high level, at least on paper. But behind the calendar and the deliverables, she is depleted. She has no margin left. She is one breaking point away from a turning point.

SHE MADE IT THROUGH. NOW SHE IS DOING THE WORK.

The Mom Rebuilding

She has been through the burnout and come out the other side, not unscathed, but wiser. She has done the hard internal work: built real boundaries, created systems at home and at work, and found or built her village.

SHE STOPPED. ON PURPOSE.

The Mom on Pause

She walked away from corporate, not because she had it all figured out, but because she needed space to think. This pause is not a failure. It is not a weakness. It is a necessary and courageous act of self-reclamation.

SAME DRIVE. NEW DIRECTION.

The Mom Reinventing

She did not leave the workforce; she left her old environment. She moved into something more aligned with her values, her season of life, and her identity as a mother. She did not abandon ambition. She redirected it.

SHE LEFT THE TABLE AND BUILT HER OWN.

The Mom Who Bet on Herself

She left corporate and built something of her own: a consulting practice, a business, a brand, a mission. Her work is an extension of who she is, and that alignment changes everything. She made the bet, and she is not looking back.

WHAT NEEDS TO CHANGE

Three levels. One redesign.

The quiet disappearance of ERGs

Employee Resource Groups were once a meaningful space for working moms inside corporate America: a place to be seen, to connect, and to advocate. But many moms interviewed noted a troubling trend. ERGs are drying up. External reporting confirms the trend: amid sweeping DEI rollbacks in 2025 and 2026, companies have defunded, rebranded, or quietly cut ties with employee resource groups, an accelerating retreat from infrastructure that helped level the playing field for women. The silence that follows is not neutral. It is a message. And many moms are receiving it loud and clear.

What companies can do

- Reinvest in ERGs and formalized support communities for working parents, particularly mothers in leadership.
- Audit the language of urgency in workplace culture. Not everything is a fire. Words shape nervous systems.
- Design flexibility that actually means rest, not just the ability to work from anywhere at any hour of the day.
- Create clear, compassionate pathways for moms experiencing burnout before they reach a breaking point.
- Invest in authentic, well-structured sponsorship programs, especially for women early in their careers.

What individuals can do

- Give yourself permission to build the village, and to pay for it. Asking for help is strategy, not weakness.
- Find your community of moms who are ahead of you on the journey.
- Start with presence. Before the systems and the boundaries and the redesign, start by putting down the phone.
- Name what is happening. Burnout thrives in silence.
- Seek out sponsors deliberately, not just mentors.

How policy needs to shift

- Parental leave policies that are generous on paper but culturally punishing in practice need to be reformed from the inside out.
- Affordable, accessible childcare, including employer-subsidized options and hands-on placement support, must be treated as core workforce infrastructure, not a personal problem parents solve on their own.
- Mental health support inside organizations must be normalized, accessible, and destigmatized.

THE PHYSIOLOGICAL TRUTH

Bringing the nervous system back down

What actually works, according to the moms who have come through it: stillness, boundaries, community, movement, therapy, and time. Not optimization. Not productivity hacks. Genuine, protected space to come back to themselves.

Structural change is necessary, but it is slow. In the meantime, there is a more urgent and more personal piece of this conversation that almost no one is addressing: the physiological one.

These women are not just tired. They are dysregulated. Their nervous systems have been living in a state of chronic activation, and no amount of vacation days or wellness stipends will undo that without intentional intervention.

Stillness. Boundaries. Community.
Movement. Therapy. Time

A note on this research. More than 20 in-depth interviews were conducted in the summer of 2026, all in confidence. No names or identifying details are used in this white paper. The goal is not to point to individual stories, but to surface the collective truth of what high-achieving moms are experiencing, and what it looks like when they find their way through. More interviews are ongoing; this document reflects findings to date.

WHERE THIS GOES FROM HERE

You are not broken.
The system didn't adjust.

If you saw yourself in these pages, in the stat boxes, in one of the five faces, in the woman answering emails at 11 p.m. while telling everyone she is fine, hear this clearly: every woman in this research who found her way through did it the same way. Not alone.

Mom Boss Wellness exists to build that way through: helping high-achieving mothers redesign daily life so they can thrive inside real responsibility. The way through is not leaning in harder.

JOIN THE CONVERSATION

Connect with Laura Gent Felker on LinkedIn or @MomBoss_Wellness on Instagram to follow the ongoing research and share your story.

SOURCES

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